

Ten Issues Facing Educators *in the Age of AI*

A report on artificial intelligence in Western North Carolina education, based on the 2026 WNC Educator Survey and two years of regional educator summits.

54

educators surveyed

9

institutions represented

27

education leaders

2

years of summits

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OVERVIEW — TOP 10 ISSUES FACING EDUCATORS

The 2026 WNC Educator Survey makes the picture clear: faculty are already engaging with AI, 65% say their institution's policy is behind or nonexistent, and 92% name loss of critical thinking as their leading concern. Students feel the pressure too. Roughly 70% of college students now see AI as a danger to their future careers.

One principle ties all ten issues together, simple enough for a sticky note:

Brain first, then AI.

Used well, AI extends what a capable person can do. Used as a substitute for learning, it removes the work that builds human understanding and capability in the first place.

1. Protecting Critical Thinking. True understanding cannot be fast-tracked; it is a deliberate, deeply human process of piecing together complex puzzles to understand and solve real-world problems. While AI provides an illusion of instant learning, education must focus on cultivating the deep critical thinking skills required to evaluate AI output, while still teaching the foundational skills.

2. Create an Open Dialog. Students use AI at home no matter what the syllabus says. Banning it ends the chance to teach good judgment around using it. The educators with the best results bring AI into the open and frame it clearly as a tool for learning and not a replacement.

3. Policy Built for a Fast-Moving Target. 65% of WNC educators say their policy is behind or absent. The cause is structural: technology changes way faster than policy can keep up. The best schools treat policy as a living document and get input from front line educators on which way to move.

4. Judging AI Output. AI never tells you when it is wrong, hallucinations are a common issue. A fabricated citation looks exactly like a real one. Critical evaluation of AI output is a literacy problem, and it is a skill that belongs in every discipline.

5. Assessment Must Shift to Process. A model can produce a competent final paper in under a minute. Educators who grade only the final product end up measuring the tool, not the student. 60% of WNC educators have already redesigned assignments toward evaluating the process.

6. Workplace Preparation Creates Tension. Employers are beginning to expect AI proficiency. But learning requires students to solve the issues themselves. A phased approach to AI introduction ensures students learn foundational skills without becoming dependent on AI in the process.

7. Training Faculty for Appropriate Use. Faculty want training and direction, not just access to models. Only 25% of WNC institutions have invested in a dedicated AI tool for their faculty.

8. AI as Institutional Infrastructure. Schools across WNC run AI for chatbots, enrollment systems, and administrative work. Done poorly, it routes a student in real need to a bot that cannot help; good support requires offering mixed help-desk options depending on the issue at hand. 60% of educators flagged data privacy directly as a concern.

9. Collaboration Beats Silos. Campuses making real progress share strategies and build common frameworks. The Land of Sky regional summits are the kind of infrastructure that makes it possible.

10. AI Cannot Replace Human Connection. In-person settings produce stronger engagement, better retention, and relationships that change a student's path. Learning ultimately works best in an engaging and cooperative environment, with active participation from students and educators.

"The desire to thoughtfully integrate AI while maintaining educational values centered on human interaction, critical thinking, and ethical responsibility."

Warren Wilson College educator respondents, 2026

The Ten Issues in Full

The essays below develop each issue and cite the research and regional practice behind it. A campus-by-campus review and an APA reference list follow.

1. Critical Thinking Skills

True understanding cannot be fast-tracked. It is a deliberate, deeply human process of working through complex problems, and AI is reshaping the conditions under which students build that capacity. AI is excellent at fast knowledge: fixing an error, defining a term, summarizing a chapter. But education has never primarily been about fast answers. It is about the slow, durable understanding that comes from sitting with something difficult, getting it wrong, and returning to it.

The research is increasingly concrete. A 2025 MIT Media Lab study found that students who relied on AI from the start showed up to 55% lower cognitive engagement than those who wrote independently, and accumulated what the authors call “cognitive debt,” a compounding deficit in recall and idea ownership (Kosmyna et al., 2025). A separate study of 666 participants found a strong negative correlation between frequent AI use and critical-thinking performance, mediated by cognitive offloading (Gerlich, 2025); related work frames this as the central paradox of AI in education, that a tool meant to support learning can quietly erode the very skills it is supposed to build (Lee et al., 2025). The practical implication is a sequence: students should engage their own thinking before AI enters the process, then use it to extend that thinking rather than replace it.

In WNC — UNCA and Blue Ridge faculty describe students bypassing the struggle phase entirely, with the cost showing up in retention and in students’ inability to explain ideas they “completed” with AI.

2. Guidance Over Prohibition

Students are already using AI at home, on their phones, before and after class. Policy that assumes prohibition can change that gives up the only conversation worth having. When use goes undisclosed, it goes unexamined, and students stop weighing what the tool costs them and start weighing only whether they will get caught. The educators with the most success bring AI into the open early, framing it the way a capable teaching assistant works: something that helps you check your thinking, not something that produces the assignment for you.

Transparency does more for academic honesty than enforcement does, because it makes the expectation legible and gives students a reason to engage in good faith.

In WNC — Montreat College labels each assignment AI Free, AI Enhanced, or AI Collaborative, so students always know the mode they are working in; Blue Ridge faculty name “over-collaboration,” AI use that quietly crosses from support into substitution, as the failure mode to watch.

3. Policy Built for a Fast-Moving Target

65% of WNC educators say their institution's AI policy is behind or nonexistent (WNC Educator Survey, 2026), but the cause is structural rather than negligent. Standard policy cycles were built for issues that hold still year to year, and the lag between capability and governance is now a documented pattern across higher education (Azevedo & Mallinson, 2025; American Association of University Professors, 2025). A year ago, prompt engineering was a teachable skill; today's models barely need it, and a module built last term can be half-obsolete before it is delivered.

The schools holding up best treat policy as a living document, revised by people actually using the tools (Wu et al., 2024), and lean on simple, tiered frameworks such as the risk-based models adapted from EU AI Act principles (Temper et al., 2025). AB Tech's red, yellow, green system is a working local example: red means no AI, yellow means disclosed or supervised use, green means open use. The shared vocabulary matters more than the exact categories.

In WNC — WCU contributed to a UNC System AI literacy course; multiple campuses favor syllabus-level disclosure over detection software, which misfires on non-native English speakers and ages into a surveillance culture.

4. Teaching Students to Judge AI Output

AI gives no signal when it is wrong, and hallucinations are common. A fabricated citation looks exactly like a real one, and a confident false paragraph reads identically to a true one. The fluency of the output earns a trust most students have not learned to withhold. This is a literacy problem, not a technology problem, and the same critical-reading practices that help a student evaluate any source apply directly to AI output.

The cost of skipping this is measurable. A 2023 review found that across sustained-AI-use contexts, over two-thirds of students showed increased cognitive passivity and more than a quarter showed degraded decision-making (Ahmad et al., 2023). Teaching students to ask “how do I know this is right?” of every output is the practice that keeps that from setting in, and 75% of WNC educators believe AI literacy should be a core competency for every student (WNC Educator Survey, 2026).

In WNC — Southwestern faculty describe students using AI and then denying it; Buncombe County Schools build the habit early by teaching students to credit AI-generated content rather than pass it off as their own.

5. Assessment Must Shift to Process

A language model can produce a competent final paper in under a minute, so an assignment graded only on its polished result measures the tool, not the student. The teachers ahead of this grade the process instead: drafts, checkpoints, oral exams, and in-person components where understanding is visible as it forms. 60% of WNC educators have already redesigned assignments this way, most on their own initiative without coordinated support (WNC Educator Survey, 2026).

This is also better pedagogy regardless of AI. Students who attempt the work before turning to AI retain significantly more than those who start with the tool (Akgun & Toker, 2024), and low-stakes retrieval practice keeps the brain engaged in the material at almost no added grading cost.

In WNC — Haywood designed “AI-resilient” assignments around process; AB Tech shifted from rote recall toward application and real-world problem solving; oral exams are spreading as a way to confirm understanding exists.

6. Workplace Preparation Creates Tension

Employers increasingly expect AI fluency, and that is fair. But foundational skills require deliberate practice, and a student who uses AI to skip that practice arrives with a surface competence that collapses the moment the tool is gone. A professional accelerating work they already understand is in a fundamentally different position than a student outsourcing the learning itself.

Behind that sits a harder worry educators should not paper over: a labor market that may use AI to replace people rather than support them, unevenly across fields. Warren Wilson respondents voiced real skepticism about how far AI should reshape certain professions, and the anxiety is not abstract. Roughly 70% of students already see AI as a threat to their careers (Harvard Kennedy School Institute of Politics, 2025), and over half of the class of 2025 are pessimistic about their prospects (Handshake, 2025). 80% of WNC educators want tighter alignment between classroom and workplace AI use (WNC Educator Survey, 2026). The workable answer is sequential: build the foundation first, then introduce AI as a professional instrument once students can already do the thinking themselves.

In WNC — 40% of WNC educators see students on free tiers disadvantaged against those who can pay for premium tools, a gap that widens with each model generation.

7. Training Faculty for Appropriate Use

Faculty are not asking for more logins; they want to be taught how to use these tools well, which is a skill in itself. Only 25% of WNC institutions provide a dedicated, secure AI tool, leaving most to teach themselves on free tiers with no structured support (WNC Educator Survey, 2026). An instructor who has never worked seriously with AI cannot model good judgment about it for students.

The split in the faculty room is real and worth naming. Some colleagues, especially in software and data fields, use these tools daily, while others have never touched them and a few refuse to engage at all, which becomes its own problem when students already are. Faculty at well-supported institutions report the highest confidence and the lowest anxiety; those left to manage it alone trend toward burnout rather than progress.

In WNC — Mars Hill runs faculty book studies and multi-campus development through its teaching center; AB Tech built collective reading initiatives and Canvas-based courses; Haywood convenes employee AI work groups alongside required security training.

8. AI as Institutional Infrastructure

AI is no longer only a classroom question. Schools across WNC run it for support chatbots, enrollment and retention analysis, and administrative automation. Done well, it extends a stretched institution's reach; done poorly, it routes a student in real trouble to a bot that cannot help and does not know when to escalate. Any student-facing system needs a clear, fast handoff to a person.

Data privacy is a serious concern at this level, flagged directly by 60% of WNC educators (WNC Educator Survey, 2026). When systems process student records, institutions owe a clear account of what is stored and who can see it. The efficiency AI buys should be reinvested in the human capacity it cannot replace, not used to justify cutting it.

In WNC — WCU runs AI projects through legal and security review before deployment; Haywood built a narrowly scoped custom GPT to help draft and review assessment reports; Mars Hill is building chatbots with escalation paths built in.

9. Collaboration Beats Silos

Institutions working in isolation fall behind; the ones sharing strategies, exchanging faculty, and building common frameworks pull ahead. Education is structurally siloed, so this does not happen on its own. Someone has to organize it and be resourced to do it, not merely volunteered into it.

Land of Sky's regional summits are exactly that kind of backbone, and the 27 leaders from 9 institutions who have taken part are evidence of real regional will. One summit is a conversation; a series with working groups and documented follow-through is infrastructure.

In WNC — WCU's UNC System course contribution and Mars Hill's multi-campus development both build things other schools can reuse; the stated goal of reaching 100 participating educators would broaden that base considerably.

10. AI Cannot Replace Physical Place or Human Connection

Online learning genuinely widens access for students managing work, family, or distance, and the honest move is to be clear about what each setting provides rather than pretend they are interchangeable. In-person environments consistently produce stronger engagement, better retention, and the professional relationships that change a student's path.

A newer concern deserves naming directly. Many students are beginning to treat AI as a friend or confidant, and that closeness makes them even less likely to question what it tells them. A chatbot never pushes back, never disagrees, never notices a student is off that day. Learning works best in an engaging, cooperative environment with active participation from both students and educators; the conversation after class, the disagreement that sharpens a room, the instructor who notices something is wrong, none of it happens in a chat window.

In WNC — Respondents named the parasocial pattern as a compounding factor in uncritical AI acceptance; for first-generation students especially, the physical campus is the support network itself.

What WNC Institutions Are Doing

These are snapshots from the regional review, not permanent descriptions. As the UNCA student researchers who compiled much of this noted, the pace of change means any such list is partly out of date the moment it is written (Brody & Edmundson, 2025).

FOUR-YEAR COLLEGES AND UNIVERSITIES

UNC Asheville FOUR-YEAR UNIVERSITY

Engaged but divided, with a decentralized, faculty-driven approach while campus-wide governance is still being built. Several respondents advocated for “critical AI literacy,” teaching students to evaluate AI systems and their consequences rather than only use them.

NC State University FOUR-YEAR UNIVERSITY

Strategic and infrastructure-focused, providing faculty with assignment-specific policy templates rather than one universal rule. Respondents flagged a concern smaller schools share: the potentially unbounded cost of keeping up with expanding AI tools.

Western Carolina University FOUR-YEAR UNIVERSITY

One of the most structured approaches in the region, running AI projects through legal and security review and keeping humans in the loop. Active in enrollment analysis, accreditation tools, and a UNC System AI literacy course.

Mars Hill University FOUR-YEAR UNIVERSITY

Highly collaborative, fostering campus-wide conversation through faculty book studies, multi-campus development, and its teaching center. Building AI study tools and chatbots to help students navigate campus resources.

Warren Wilson College FOUR-YEAR LIBERAL ARTS

Cautious and engaged, focused on preserving human connection while preparing students for an AI-influenced workforce. Skeptical about how far AI should reshape certain professions; overall tone is cautious optimism.

Brevard College FOUR-YEAR LIBERAL ARTS

Actively integrating through access and flexible policy, with Gemini and NotebookLM available to all students. The main hurdle is literacy: weak prompting leaves many faculty and students frustrated and the tools underused.

Montreat College FOUR-YEAR UNIVERSITY

Proactive and philosophically grounded, approaching AI through ethics and cybersecurity, with a ratified institutional statement guiding policy. Its AI Free / Enhanced / Collaborative assignment labels are the clearest transparency tool in the region.

COMMUNITY COLLEGES

AB Technical Community College COMMUNITY COLLEGE

Among the most active institutions, with multiple task forces, a detailed Policy 115, and the region’s only institution-wide AI learning goals. Faculty teach students to recognize hallucinations and frame AI as a “thinking partner,” not an answer machine.

Blue Ridge Community College COMMUNITY COLLEGE

Actively exploring while guarding academic integrity, naming “over-collaboration” as the key failure mode. AI is especially contested in the sciences, where process and analytical reasoning are considered foundational.

Haywood Community College COMMUNITY COLLEGE

Planning through a steering committee on AI processes and procurement, while managing faculty resistance to changing assignments and rising proctoring demand. Built a narrowly scoped custom GPT to help draft and review assessment reports.

Southwestern Community College COMMUNITY COLLEGE

Expanding AI education with training sessions, drop-in discussions, and a new AI certificate in development. The central integrity challenge is students using AI and then denying it; most decisions still rest with individual instructors.

K–12

Buncombe County Schools K–12 DISTRICT

Cautious and ethics-centered, emphasizing responsible use, digital citizenship, and student safety. Teachers report more training on using AI tools than on teaching students about them, a gap worth closing.

The Region at a Decision Point

WNC’s educators are not starting from zero. The summits, the conversations, and the faculty who worked this out in their own classrooms are making real progress.

The research is consistent about the stakes. Unstructured AI use produces measurable cognitive deficits (Kosmyrna et al., 2025; Gerlich, 2025). A policy vacuum produces uneven and inequitable classrooms. Faculty left to manage this alone burn out. These are not projections; they are the direction the region drifts in the absence of deliberate effort.

The opportunity is just as concrete. WNC has a network of educators who show up, talk to each other, and want to get this right, and it has the regional infrastructure to support them. What is missing is the institutional commitment to fund that infrastructure and keep it running. The ten issues here are not a wish list. They are a workplan.

CAMPUS COMPARISON — SPRING 2025

Institution	Task Force	Policy	Programs / Courses	Admin AI
Appalachian State University	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
AB Technical Community College	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Blue Ridge Community College	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
Brevard College	No	Yes	Yes	No
Haywood Community College	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
Mars Hill University	No	No	No	No
Montreat College	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Southwest Community College	No	Yes	Yes	No
UNC Asheville	No*	Yes	Yes	Yes
Warren Wilson College	No	No	No	Yes
Western Carolina University	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

* UNCA task force inactive as of the reporting period; systemic changes under planning. Source: Brody & Edmundson campus review, Spring 2025. Conditions have changed rapidly since data collection.

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Formatted in APA 7th edition style. Several entries should be verified against original sources before publication (see note from the editor).

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